

**NAME OF SCHOOL: MATER MISERICORDIAE SECONDARY SCHOOL,
RUMOMASI**

TERM: FIRST 2026/2027 ACADEMIC SESSION

WEEK: ONE

CLASS: SS1

SUBJECT: Government

TOPIC: Meaning & Scope of Government

Introduction

- Government has three related meanings: the institution of the state (the organs and processes that make and enforce laws), the body of people who govern (the executive), and the process/art of governing (political leadership).

Functions of government

- Making and enforcing laws; maintaining internal order and security; defending the state against external aggression; providing public services (education, health, roads, water); promoting economic development and managing the economy; conducting foreign relations; ensuring justice and protecting citizens' rights.

Why we study government

- To understand how states are organised and governed; to know the rights and duties of citizens; to understand political concepts (power, authority, sovereignty); to develop the capacity to participate, analyse policies and vote wisely; for careers in law, politics, diplomacy and public service.

Scope of government

- Government as an academic discipline covers: political concepts (power, authority, legitimacy, sovereignty); types of government; constitutions and constitutionalism; the organs of government; democracy and elections; political parties and pressure groups; local and international politics (ECOWAS, AU, UN).

CLASS EVALUATION

1. State the three meanings of government.
2. List five functions of government.
3. Why do we study government?
4. Define sovereignty.

**NAME OF SCHOOL: MATER MISERICORDIAE SECONDARY SCHOOL,
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TERM: FIRST 2026/2027 ACADEMIC SESSION

WEEK: TWO

CLASS: SS1

SUBJECT: Government

TOPIC: Power, Authority & Legitimacy

Introduction

- Power is the ability to compel obedience or to influence the behaviour of others. Authority is the legitimate right to exercise power. Legitimacy is the acceptance of a government's right to rule by the governed.

Sources of power

- Coercion (force); authority (legality); influence (persuasion, charisma); position (office); resources (wealth, rewards); expertise (knowledge); tradition (custom); manipulation (propaganda). Governments combine force and legitimacy to stay in power.

Types of authority (Max Weber)

- **Traditional authority** — based on custom and long-standing practice (monarchs, chiefs).
- **Charismatic authority** — based on the exceptional qualities of a leader (a revolutionary or founding leader).
- **Legal-rational authority** — based on laws, offices and rules (elected governments, civil servants) — the authority of modern democracies.

Legitimacy and its sources

- Legitimacy comes from elections, the constitution, tradition, performance and consent of the people. Power without legitimacy is naked force and usually unstable.

CLASS EVALUATION

1. Distinguish between power and authority.
2. Explain the three types of authority.
3. What is legitimacy?
4. Why is legitimacy important for a stable government?

**NAME OF SCHOOL: MATER MISERICORDIAE SECONDARY SCHOOL,
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TERM: FIRST 2026/2027 ACADEMIC SESSION

WEEK: THREE

CLASS: SS1

SUBJECT: Government

TOPIC: Forms of Government

Introduction

- Forms of government describe who rules and how power is gained and exercised. They are classified by the number of rulers, the distribution of power and the relationship between organs of state.

By number of rulers

- **Monarchy** — rule by one (king/queen): absolute or constitutional.
- **Oligarchy** — rule by a few (a class, a military junta, an aristocracy).
- **Democracy** — government of the people, by the people, for the people: direct (all citizens vote on every issue, as in ancient Athens) or indirect/representative (citizens elect representatives — modern democracies like Nigeria, USA, UK).

By distribution of power

- **Unitary** — one central government controls the whole state (UK, Ghana) with local units created and controlled by the centre.
- **Federal** — power constitutionally shared between the central and component state governments, each with its own sphere (Nigeria, USA).
- **Confederation** — a loose union of states with the centre subordinate to members (ECOWAS in form).

Other classifications

- Presidential (separation of powers, e.g. Nigeria, USA) vs parliamentary (fusion of powers, e.g. UK); civil vs military; democratic vs authoritarian/totalitarian.

CLASS EVALUATION

1. Define democracy.
2. Differentiate between unitary and federal government with examples.
3. What is the difference between presidential and parliamentary systems?
4. State two advantages of a federal system.

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TERM: FIRST 2026/2027 ACADEMIC SESSION

WEEK: FOUR

CLASS: SS1

SUBJECT: Government

TOPIC: Constitution & Constitutionalism

Introduction

- A constitution is the body of rules, written and unwritten, that defines the organs of the state, their powers and the rights of citizens. Constitutionalism is the observance of these rules — government according to the constitution, with limited powers.

Types of constitution

- **Written vs unwritten** — Nigeria and the USA have written constitutions (codified documents); the UK has an unwritten constitution (statutes, conventions, case law).
- **Rigid vs flexible** — a rigid constitution is difficult to amend (Nigeria requires a two-thirds majority in both chambers and two-thirds of state houses of assembly); a flexible one is amended like ordinary law (UK).
- **Federal vs unitary** — a federal constitution shares power between levels; the unitary constitution concentrates it.

Features of a good constitution

- It is brief but clear; defines and limits the powers of government; provides for the separation of powers and checks and balances; guarantees fundamental human rights; is supreme above all other laws; is amendable; reflects the people's customs and aspirations.

Constitutionalism

- Constitutionalism means that even the government itself is subject to the law — no rule of men, but rule of law. Its absence leads to arbitrary rule even when a constitution exists on paper.

CLASS EVALUATION

1. Define constitution.
2. Differentiate rigid and flexible constitution with examples.
3. State four features of a good constitution.
4. What is constitutionalism?

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TERM: FIRST 2026/2027 ACADEMIC SESSION

WEEK: FIVE

CLASS: SS1

SUBJECT: Government

TOPIC: Separation of Powers & Checks and Balances

Introduction

- Separation of powers is the doctrine (by Montesquieu) that the three organs of government — executive, legislature and judiciary — should be in different hands so that power does not concentrate and become tyrannical.

The three organs and their functions

- **Legislature** — makes laws, approves budgets, checks the executive (National Assembly: Senate and House of Representatives).
- **Executive** — implements laws and runs the government (the President and his ministers).
- **Judiciary** — interprets laws, settles disputes, protects rights and reviews the constitutionality of laws (courts: Supreme Court, Court of Appeal, Federal High Courts, State High Courts).

Checks and balances

- The legislature can override a presidential veto, impeach the president and confirm appointments; the executive can veto bills and appoint judges; the judiciary can declare acts of the other organs unconstitutional. These mutual checks prevent abuse of power.

Limitations in practice

- Absolute separation is impossible: the president signs bills (legislative function) while the Senate confirms appointments (executive function). Party discipline may weaken checks; the fusion of powers in the parliamentary system merges executive and legislature.

CLASS EVALUATION

1. Explain separation of powers.
2. State the main function of each organ of government.
3. Give two examples of checks the judiciary has on the other organs.
4. Why is absolute separation of powers impossible?

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TERM: FIRST 2026/2027 ACADEMIC SESSION

WEEK: SIX

CLASS: SS1

SUBJECT: Government

TOPIC: Rule of Law & Democratic Principles

Introduction

- The rule of law is the principle (popularised by A.V. Dicey) that every person — including the government — is subject to the law, and that the law is supreme.

Principles of the rule of law

- **Supremacy of the law** — the law is above every person and authority; no one is punished except for a breach of the law.
- **Equality before the law** — everyone, rich or poor, official or citizen, is treated alike by the courts.
- **Fundamental human rights** — individual rights are protected by the courts (fair hearing, presumption of innocence).

Democracy and its principles

- Popular sovereignty (the people are the source of power); periodic free and fair elections; majority rule with minority rights; the rule of law; political tolerance and pluralism; transparency and accountability; protection of human rights; separation of powers; free press and civil society.

Obstacles to the rule of law in practice

- Immunity clauses, corruption, delay of justice, poverty (which denies access to lawyers), ignorance of the law, executive lawlessness and the use of state power against opponents.

CLASS EVALUATION

1. Define the rule of law.
2. State its three principles.
3. List five principles of democracy.
4. Mention two obstacles to the rule of law in Nigeria.